MONTHLY UPDATE

Nigeria: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-12 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA

Summary of the month

A Lagos High Court judge held on 25 September that Meta's behavioural advertising is unlawful under the Constitution and the data protection Act, and Meta filed a notice of appeal on 30 September. The central bank's circular requiring payments data to be stored locally takes effect on 1 January 2027. The National Payment Stack passed 100 million successful transactions. The regulator and the operators' association launched zero-rated access to approved educational platforms, starting with 5,000 learners, and the customs service finalised negotiations with the United Kingdom on a data-sharing agreement.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The IT agency issued a cloud package of four frameworks headed by a National Cloud Computing Guideline. The public service reform bureau's director general said on 30 September that the President has approved renewal of the National Strategy on Public Service Reforms, the revision to take in policies on artificial intelligence and blockchain in the public service; neither the approval date nor the new text is given.

Legislation and regulation

The platform penalty moved toward a deal: Meta is negotiating a settlement with the commission after a first appeal was rejected, on a single paywalled account. The Nigerian Fintech Regulatory Commission Bill passed second reading in the House of Representatives in October 2025 and had a public hearing on 2 March 2026; it would create a single licensing gateway beside the central bank and the securities regulator, and is still pending.

Lagos State said it is working on an innovation bill to give research and innovation incentives, dedicated funding and a legal basis, with no timeline.

Data protection

The commission opened a second framework alongside its enforcement work: validation of a data privacy framework for electronic commerce, at an Abuja workshop run with the German development agency and following a private-sector session in Lagos. No draft text, scope, commencement date or enforcement route is published, so what exists is a consultation rather than an instrument.

The consultation acquired a political timetable on 10 September, when the education minister trailed regulation of internet access for children under 16, to be announced by the security agencies within days or weeks. The announcement is to come from the security agencies rather than a regulator, and no draft instrument is named.

The commission moved into a new Abuja headquarters on 14 September, reporting 356 licensed compliance organisations, and its chief executive put compliance among advertising agencies at 12.3%. The data-protection commission and the orientation agency signed a memorandum on public data-protection awareness.

A law firm reported that the Federal High Court in Lagos held on 17 July 2026 that the data protection commission acted within its powers in designating point-of-sale operators as controllers and processors of major importance, so that they must register and pay the prescribed fees. The judgment itself is not held.

Regional collaboration

The customs service and HM Revenue and Customs met in Abuja on 25-26 September 2026 to finalise a mutual administrative assistance agreement on customs information sharing; signing is hoped for in December. Nigeria's and Benin's customs piloted the interconnection of their systems at Seme-Krake from 11 September. A Lagos workshop on 16-17 September set out the terms of issue of the ECOWAS biometric identity card, and ministers of Chad and Nigeria held talks on fibre connectivity and AI in N'Djamena on 16 September.

Standards

The device register went live and met resistance. The board stated the Device Management System live, blocking stolen devices across networks, while manufacturers asked for a longer implementation timeline against a charge of about N670 per IMEI.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The one memorandum signed in the window is domestic: the technology development agency and the national chambers of commerce signed an agreement on small-business digital adoption on the sidelines of GITEX Nigeria, covering a shared enterprise platform, capacity building and the national digital conference, with no sum or deliverable attached.

The central bank signed a memorandum of understanding in Singapore with the Global Finance & Technology Network, setting a framework for cooperation between the two countries' financial-innovation sectors. The signing date is not stated.

New investments

A US$110m debt facility for technology startups opened for applications on 30 July.

The lending frame around all of it was settled earlier in the summer and its numbers reached the public in two different ways. The World Bank's Executive Directors endorsed the country partnership framework for FY26-FY32 on 29 June and approved a US$1.25bn development policy operation alongside it, whose reform programme includes modernising the regulatory framework for the digital economy and e-governance. The framework itself sets an indicative IDA envelope of about US$5.7bn over the IDA21 period on top of an ongoing programme of over US$16.9bn, and puts its digital commitment as broadband access for more than 58 million Nigerians against a stated baseline of 39% of the population using the internet in 2023 and fixed broadband penetration of 8.4% — and attaches no sum to that target. The sums circulating against it, a US$500m programme for resilient digital infrastructure and a second US$500m pipeline programme, come from a fact sheet handed out at a Lagos forum on 19 August rather than from the framework document, which the newspaper carrying them states on the record. A target with no line against it and a line with no document behind it are different problems, and this month produced one of each.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Lagos put a figure on its own build. The state says it has laid about 3,000km of a planned 6,000km unified fibre network between 2019 and 2025 and plans to secure 200-400MW of state-procured electricity, alongside a claim of more than US$80bn in commitments to technology development. Both figures are the state's own, given at a trade exhibition, with no route, cost or independent verification published.

Operators are two-thirds of the way to their site commitments: the regulator's board recorded 8,526 of 12,179 committed coverage and capacity sites deployed, up from about 5,000 at its previous meeting, and blamed fibre cuts for a sharp rise in June disruptions.

The tower programme set a first milestone and the satellite programme a first contract. The ministry said at least 200 towers will be live by December, and Thales Alenia Space signed to build NigComSat-2A. A second virtual network operator began commercial service.

Rural connectivity was folded into the electrification programme. A rural infrastructure company secured a World Bank-backed results-based facility to deploy 2G, 4G, broadband and community Wi-Fi in 500 unserved and underserved communities under the US$750m DARES programme with the Rural Electrification Agency. The account rests on documents seen by one newspaper and gives no facility amount or signing date.

A rural network operator announced a pilot of licensed satellite backhaul at one rural site with its partner Infratel, buying the service through third-party resellers; no start date or result is published.

An operator executive said at the regulator's investment forum on 29 September that more than 13 states had removed right-of-way fees or cut them to the federal benchmark of N145 per metre, adding that separate state road-reinstatement charges offset the saving.

Data Storage

A rating agency put a third count on the estate and named the constraint. It puts national data-centre capacity at about 197 MW, below Saudi Arabia's 435 MW, and classifies the country's power availability for data-centre development as very low, citing heavy reliance on self-generation and backup power, limited renewable transmission and chronic grid instability. The figure is on a third basis again and reconciles with neither of the two the repository already holds; what it adds is the finding that power, not demand, is what would stop the country converting artificial-intelligence interest into operating capacity.

Cybersecurity

The national response team recorded a rise in high-impact incidents across sectors on 15 September, driven by phishing, ransomware, business email compromise and data breaches, and on 22 September warned of an escalation of Phobos ransomware attacks on managed cloud service providers whose clients include government agencies, banks and telecommunications firms, rating the damage critical and the probability high. Neither advisory publishes an incident count or names an affected organisation.

DPI

Data Exchange

The education repository put figures against its institution count. It now holds 907 enrolled institutions — 259 universities and 163 polytechnics among them — past 400,000 theses and dissertations with 115,000 credentials verified, reported on 7 September. Submissions run 409,456 undergraduate against 1,563 postgraduate, a ratio of 262 to one, so what is being built is a record of first degrees.

Three more exchanges were proposed in September, none yet built. The education ministry disclosed talks with the national youth service scheme on an interface to verify qualifications against the repository; at Seme-Krake the customs service offered Benin real-time exchange of declarations, manifests, transit data, risk profiles and enforcement alerts, the two administrations sharing one post but no system; and the financial intelligence unit opened co-design with banks, fintechs and insurers of a platform to share intelligence against illicit flows. None states a legal basis for the sharing. The disease control centre signed a memorandum to pilot automated disease reporting from private facilities into its surveillance system, with no start date stated.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A state credential went further than the national one. Lagos made the residents registration number mandatory for admission and enrolment in every public and private school in the state, schools required to record a valid number from 14 September, the stated purpose being a verifiable learner database for planning, monitoring and service delivery. No exemption, appeal route or treatment of unregistered children is stated, and the credential is the state's rather than the national identity number.

The identity count was split in two on 7 September, and the halves do not agree with what anyone had been quoting. Closing the remaining gap would need monthly enrolment to rise from 1.5–1.8 million to about 7.4 million with six months left. Five days earlier the commission had put its own count at about 140 million, alongside enrolment time cut from seven days to one hour, in the course of describing itself under the 2026 Act as a national trust authority rather than an identity register. Three numbers, none reconciled.

A second use for election hardware was floated rather than agreed: the admissions board asked the electoral commission for biometric verification machines that sit idle between elections, and the commission ordered a proof of concept on whether they are fit for it. No device count, transfer basis or data-protection assessment is published, and the two registers rest on separate legal bases.

The government then set itself a nearer deadline: 95 per cent identity number coverage by December 2026, announced on 16 September with the database put at nearly 140 million, a figure above the 117.5 million issued numbers the lender recorded for June.

On 23 September the identity commission denied that identity numbers and other personal data had been breached and offered for sale, and its Director-General ordered an investigation into whether licensed tokenisation verification agents had breached their licences, directly or through sub-licensees. No finding or timetable is published. A technology outlet reported that a presidential directive orders every ministry, department and agency to adopt the authentication service as its default identity check. The supervising minister said implementation of the national cooperative identity reform had commenced at no cost to government, and tasked the states to support it. Katsina State sought a partnership with the national identity commission, reported 10 October 2026, to integrate its identity management system with the national architecture; the two agreed a technical working group to draft a framework and memorandum within eight weeks.

Digital Payments and Fintech

One private figure crossed a round number. A digital bank passed 30 million registered users in Nigeria on its own count, which is a registration total rather than an active or transacting one and has no earlier figure on the ledger to read it against.

The survey behind the country's headline inclusion figure entered the repository in full, and it is three years old. Formal financial inclusion reached 64% of adults, about 71.7 million, in 2023 from 56% in 2020, banking uptake moving 51% to 52% and non-bank formal products 32% to 57%, on 26,930 interviews across all 36 states and the federal capital territory; exclusion fell ten percentage points, but roughly 28.9 million adults remain outside the formal system and the share counted financially healthy fell to 16%. Fieldwork ran August to October 2023, so every payment-system change since sits outside it.

On the cross-border rail the operator reported Nigeria–Rwanda volumes approaching and in places exceeding Nigeria–Ghana, corridors with Cameroon, Niger and Benin growing on trade in Nigerian goods, and church contributions remitted from elsewhere in Africa as a notable component of activity — no volumes, values or period attached to any of it. In the other direction, diaspora inflows held steady at US$21.8bn in 2025 on central bank figures, against an average 8.46% cost to send US$200 into the region and app-based rivals quoting 2–3% on the London–Lagos corridor.

A new inclusion survey replaced the 2023 baseline. The 2026 round puts digital financial services use at 64 per cent of adults from 47 per cent, mobile money at 38 per cent from 12 per cent, and exclusion at 21 per cent, with 53 per cent of the poorest fifth still excluded and 92 per cent of agricultural workers paid in cash. The same round puts overall use at 79 per cent of adults and formal inclusion at 73 per cent, past the national strategy's 70 per cent target. At its launch the central bank said it had completed its review of the third inclusion strategy and begun the fourth, and the trade minister inaugurated a steering committee for a strategy to let firms borrow against verified digital invoices.

Two private rails widened what they carry. Remita, whose rails carry government and enterprise payments, launched a consumer super app on 22 September with multi-bank aggregation, transfers to other African countries over the continental rail and a loans marketplace matching borrowers on NIN and BVN verification; no user or transfer figure is published. Moniepoint began selling shares in the Dangote refinery's public offer through its agent terminals in all 774 local government areas, buyers identified by BVN and capped at N100,000 each.

The clearing operator said its ISO 20022 payment stack had passed 100 million successful transactions by late September, on its own figure, with no value or institution count given. A banking group's audited half-year statements put its payments subsidiary's profit at NGN 7.81bn, the first position the repository holds on that switch. A listing prospectus, as reported, shows a central bank directive required an operator's mobile-money arm to hand its 25% stake in a payment service bank back to the network company.

Registries

The electoral roll got its own numbers on 8 September. The commission said the register was approaching 100 million ahead of the 2027 general elections, on 10,772,421 new registrants in the latest continuous registration exercise, with a real-time election readiness tracker to be deployed across the 36 states and the federal capital territory. The totals are its own and no register audit or duplicate rate accompanies them, though on 15 September the commission told an African Union mission it has integrated national identity numbers into cleaning the register; and the devices that read the roll failed at a state election three weeks earlier.

A second register was put on the same path, without a date. The maritime administration says it is moving towards full automation of the Nigerian ship registry so that operators can register and transact remotely, including payment, without attending its offices, framed as part of reforms to remove human contact, block revenue leakages and cut delays. It is a statement of direction: no date, cost or vendor accompanies it.

The companies registry announced AI across business registration with Google, in English, Hausa, Yoruba, Igbo and Pidgin, with no contract or launch date published. The postal service launched the national digital postcode system on 1 October, and the communications ministry opened its API to organisations that pass business verification; no coverage figure is published. The communications ministry describes the postcode as an 11-character code for every addressable location, looked up at postcode.gov.ng. The electoral commission's chairman said the register stands at more than 103 million after the final biometric clean-up, with card collection nationwide from 9 October.

Sectoral management information systems

The delivery end of the social-protection architecture failed its audit. The Auditor-General's 2024 report states that the government could not provide auditors with sufficient evidence that ₦33.75bn of cash transfers intended for more than 3,295,207 vulnerable households reached genuine beneficiaries, the payment platform's statements not having been supplied, and a civil-society organisation puts over ₦78.8bn across social protection programmes as diverted, unaccounted for or irregularly spent. The audit report itself is not held, and no response from the agencies named is on file — but the finding is about the same register and the same rail the unified architecture is being designed on top of.

The health ministry inaugurated the steering committee of a new office to coordinate, standardise and integrate health technology and data systems, charged with implementing the national digital health architecture. No staffing or budget is published.

The Gates Foundation and MTN's group foundation announced a maternal health programme on 23 September with an initial investment of about US$25m for 2026 to 2030, combining AI-enabled decision support for health workers and mothers with affordable phones, data and facility connectivity, and targeting 500,000 women, 5,000 health workers and 500 facilities by 2030. The funders' shares are not stated.

The statistics bureau, the ILO and UNICEF opened a three-day dialogue on 22 September to introduce a Social Protection Management Information System and agree regular sharing of administrative data the ILO calls fragmented and inconsistent, after pilots in four states under an EU-funded programme; no outcome is yet reported.

Opening a dialogue on the AGROW programme on 29 September, the agriculture minister called for a national digital farmers register, with states leading enumeration and verification, a federal agricultural data department coordinating one interoperable standard, and farmers linked to their national identity number.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A state payroll moved onto one record. Ondo State launched Ondo Pay on 4 September, bringing employee records, salary computation, approvals, reporting, payroll processing and pension migration into one environment with a mobile self-service application for payslips and permitted record updates; the state says bank-verification-number integration, controlled access and auditable workflows are meant to remove duplicate and non-genuine records and unauthorised payments. No cost, vendor or headcount is published, so the claim cannot be tested against a payroll figure.

The police opened a public fraud-reporting channel on 1 September, and it is the fourth such platform in a decade. The app lets people report suspected financial fraud, upload evidence, track cases and receive feedback, built by the force's own ICT department with financial-sector stakeholders, and it arrives over a cybercrime centre already logging about 146,000 reports and about ₦58bn in recovered assets. Nothing published says how the new channel routes against the centre already running, or what became of the three earlier platforms.

Two September measures reach further into the state. A single 112 emergency number, approved by the National Economic Council, went to a rollout committee of the police, communications regulator, emergency agency and road safety corps on 8 September, with funding promised once the roadmap exists. And the procurement bureau's Digital Submission Portal was made mandatory for every federal agency's procurement requests, an internal record that publishes no award. On the one citizen survey held, digital-government adoption stands at 50% while net satisfaction fell five points from 2024 to 64%.

Ondo State followed its payroll platform with Ondo AI, launched to automate personnel administration, payroll, retirement processing and pension migration. The report does not say whether it is the same platform as Ondo Pay or a second one, and gives no launch date.

The National Assembly's library trust fund said on 28 September it is building electronic repositories, a legislative app and a Bills Tracker, and will translate federal laws into Hausa, Yoruba, Igbo and other Nigerian languages. No launch date is stated.

The state network operator said more than 30 federal agencies have moved onto one platform for paperless approval of documents and memos, with no list of agencies or adoption target.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

One state measured its own agencies rather than announcing a platform. The Anambra ICT agency assessed about 25 ministries, departments and agencies for digital compliance, data protection and readiness to deliver services digitally, reporting compliance with the 2023 data protection Act as uncertain in some of them and records management uneven. No scoring method, agency list or published report is held.

A UK-funded programme of state-level digital policy and institutional reform was inaugurated in Abia on 17 September, run by a Nigerian NGO and starting from a baseline report on the state.

Edo State replaced a foreign-owned e-governance platform, for which it paid licence fees after funding its build, with a platform of its own serving all 128 state ministries, departments and agencies, the head of the state ICT agency said on 23 September. The date of the switch is not stated.

Rural digital data capture

The regulator's investment forum resolved on a blended funding model for community-owned rural networks, with a six-month target to secure funding.

Technology

AI

On 24 September the electoral commission's chairman said it had begun deploying AI checks inside results management to flag discrepancies before final validation, each subject to human audit, under a new AI Division and an AI Roadmap and Governance Framework, four months before the 2027 general elections. The framework text is not held. The technology agency published an advisory warning against entering identity numbers, bank details or confidential data into public AI tools. An opposition movement called on the electoral commission to abandon AI verification of results until its governance framework is published.

ICT Industry

The communications minister put the ICT sector's contribution to GDP at about 21 per cent, up from about 16 per cent in three years. A consultancy procurement opened on 21 September for a programme to build a knowledge-services export industry, with a 1,000-graduate academy. The software industry association committed on 10 September to launch a national software industry registry within six months. OPay filed a registration statement in the United States on 9 October 2026 for a New York listing. The filing shows a South African banking group's unit buying up to US$200m of shares in a private placement alongside the offering, and 50.1 million monthly active users at end-July 2026.

Innovation ecosystem

At its Abuja forum on 9 September the EU put a figure on Boost Africa: EUR108 million invested across Africa, stated to have attracted about EUR400 million more and up to 15,000 jobs, cumulative rather than a Nigerian commitment.

A US$12m Korean-funded Abuja Centre for Entrepreneurship is under construction with the small-enterprise agency and UNDP, US$5.9m for the building and US$6.1m for equipment and programmes, targeting 1,500 small businesses; no completion date is given.

Capacity

Training and skills

The federal training academy launched on 14 September with more than N10.5bn committed for over 32,000 trainees. Free digital and employability training opened for 50,000 young people in the North-Central states and the federal capital, towards a national target of 300,000. The regulator said its training institute has been designated an ITU Digital Transformation Centre.

Inclusion

Access to services

Zero-rated education access moved from consultation to a start date. At the 10 September launch the education minister set 1 October 2026 for about five million students to receive 100MB a day on approved educational platforms, public senior secondary and tertiary students first, through participating mobile operators. No approved-platform list or funding arrangement is published, and the minister's own caution that zero rating should not open every platform calling itself educational leaves the whitelist the open question.

A wider sample gave a less bleak figure: 47% of about 30 government digital platforms met an accessibility threshold in an assessment presented to the technology agency, which said it is considering national accessibility standards.

An urban survey of 13,251 respondents in 12 cities, published in September by a consultancy and an operator group, put smartphone ownership at 75% in 2025 against 64% in 2023, and found more than a third of mobile subscribers still on 2G in May 2026.

A second UK-sponsored community connectivity hub was commissioned at Amuvi in Arochukwu, Abia State, offering free internet access and free eight-week digital-skills training for 100 people. Civil-society organisations reported on 2 October that access to TikTok over mobile data has been disrupted in Kaduna, Kebbi, Kano and Sokoto since about 14 September, across more than one provider; no authority, operator or the platform has explained it, and the organisations say they cannot establish the cause. The 2026 access-to-finance survey finds only 30.7 per cent of formally included adults financially healthy. A foundation filed a fundamental-rights suit against the platform over restricted access in four northern states.

Digital divides

A civil-society account on 24 September reported the national strategy for community-centred connectivity moving into implementation, with regulators estimating over 100,000 communities potentially eligible and an aggregator licensing model under study.

Data

National statistics

The agriculture ministry said on 29 September it had finalised a Federal Department of Agricultural Data and Analytics to coordinate a single standard for a national farmers register. No establishing instrument is held.

Open data

The month's open-data movement is civil society's rather than government's. A civic-technology foundation published a 2026-2030 strategy on 3 September to institutionalise participatory budgeting and subnational public-project tracking in 10 to 15 states, building on two existing platforms that let citizens monitor budget implementation and identify completed, delayed or abandoned public projects. No budget, funder, delivery timetable or state is named.

Government procurement went the other way: online, but not open. The procurement bureau's submission portal became mandatory for agencies while contract awards, prices and delivery stay unpublished, although the 2007 procurement Act and the 2011 freedom of information Act require award particulars to be.

Use of satellite data

The innovation minister said the Federal Executive Council has approved a programme of six new satellites, four of them Earth-observation, and a Centre for Space Transport and Propulsion, and sought private and foreign partners at the space summit in Paris. No manufacturer, cost, launch date or use for the data is given, and whether the two communications satellites are the ones approved in August is not stated.

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